

GAME-MASTER'S SETUP GUIDE • REMOVE THESE LEAVES BEFORE SHE ARRIVES

MINUTE ONE

HANDED TO HER: the letter and the Milk Crate painting.
The letter gives her the address sarahs.quest.

OUT IN THE OPEN: seven printed sheets (not the pig-pen
key, not the plates), the flyer, the lemons, the knife AND
the scale, The Prophet, the locked suitcase.

OPEN AT THE SAME TIME • two lines, either order

Milk Crate painting, back → Ed Sheeran

Stars and Their Notes → The Barista's Hornpipe, two notes

Parlour Songbook, those two shapes → 12 and 15

Concordance + The Prophet, pages 12 and 15 → CORN BREAD

Receipt Book, cornbread → a game of backgammon

HIDE IN THE BACKGAMMON SET:
Plate II (the small disc with the hands) + Patricia painting

Put the knife on the scale → 79 g

Knife Catalogue, 79 g → No. 9, the Lemonade Knife

Cut the lemons open → the Joker

Cartomancer's Guide, the Joker → in the Dutch oven

HIDE IN THE DUTCH OVEN:
Plate I (the big dial), with a paper fastener taped to it

OPENS WHEN THE MUSIC LINE IS DONE

Patricia painting → Register → a small painted egg...

HIDE IN THE WINGSPAN BOX:
Hamlet painting · fairy painting · a Queen of Hearts

THREE AT ONCE • any order

Queen of Hearts → Cartomancer's Guide
→ the back of the upstairs toilet

HIDE IN THE TOILET CISTERN:
the BLACK key (opens the suitcase)

Hamlet → Hamnet → Chloé Zhao
→ Register, Chloe → a jar of sweets

HIDE IN THE CANDY JAR:
blue-light pen · the framer's card

Fairy houses → Shirley
→ Register → a bottle kept for company

HIDE IN THE LIQUOR CABINET:
the Pig-Pen Alphabet sheet

THE LOCK • needs a piece from every line

Framer's card → both paintings. With the pigpen sheet:
sarahs.quest → Ethiopia = Figure VII (HALF PAST),
Italy = Figure XIV (THREE). The hour is 3:30.

Flyer → bathroom. Blue-light pen + pigpen sheet.
Marker: ALIEN BLUES. Invisible ink, in the gaps:
BREATHE / BREATHE / GREEN / SIT

HIDE INSIDE THE MEDITATION CUSHION:
the card: DW₅OY₇ H₃W VKYJ LKRWQ

THE WHEEL: pin Plate II (hands) on Plate I (dial), set 3:30, decode the card
DW₅OY₇ H₃W VKYJ LKRWQ = BEHIND THE MANY FACES

HIDE BEHIND THE FRAMED PHOTO PUZZLE: the DARK BLUE key

BLACK key, from the cistern, opens the SUITCASE
early on. Inside: the backpack, still locked.

DARK BLUE key opens the BACKPACK
the prize

Nothing can be shortcut: the card is unreadable without both plates and the time, and those come from three different places.

PLAIN ENGLISH FOR THE THINGS WITH ODD NAMES

THE CONCORDANCE

The one-page sheet headed "A Reader's Concordance" with "The Prophet, by Kahlil Gibran" printed under the masthead. It gives one word-counting rule for each of 84 pages. She needs a real copy of The Prophet to use it; the sheet itself names the book, so put the book on the shelf among others and nothing more is needed.

PLATE I AND PLATE II

"Plate" always means one of the two cipher discs, and nothing else. Plate I, The Dial, is the big circle with clock numerals round the rim. Plate II, The Hands, is the smaller circle with two clock hands on it. Cut both out. Tape a paper fastener to Plate I (the brass pin with a round head and two flat legs, from any office-supply shop; a pushpin into cardboard works too); she lays Plate II on top and turns it until the hands read 3:30. So "hide Plate I in the Dutch oven" simply means: put the big disc in the Dutch oven.

FIGURE I TO FIGURE XX

The twenty flag cards on sarahs.quest. They carry no country names, only numbers, so Figure VII is the seventh card along. She never needs the number; she recognises Ethiopia and Italy by their colours. The numbers are only here so you can check the right card without counting.

PIGPEN

A cipher where each letter is drawn as the walls of the box it sits in. The printed Pig-Pen Alphabet sheet is the key. The only pigpen you write by hand is the wall; the flags' pigpen is already on the website.

WHEEL SYMBOLS

Ordinary letters and digits that only mean something once the wheel is set. You copy them onto the cushion card exactly as printed below.

LOCK AND LOAD, IN THIS ORDER, SO NO KEY ENDS UP LOCKED INSIDE ITS OWN BOX

1. Put the prize in the backpack. Close it and padlock it. Its key is **DARK BLUE**.
2. Put the backpack inside the suitcase. Close the suitcase and padlock it. Its key is **BLACK**.
3. Stand the suitcase somewhere she will see it all evening. It is meant to taunt.
4. Hide **BLACK** in a ziplock in the toilet cistern. She reaches it mid-game, opens the suitcase, and finds the backpack still locked. That is the moment the evening turns.
5. Tape **DARK BLUE** flat to the back of the framed photo puzzle. Masking tape, pressed down so it cannot rattle. Nothing points here until the wheel is decoded.
6. **PURPLE** and **LIGHT BLUE** are not used. Put them in a drawer.

Two locks is the whole scheme. The wheel exists to produce the second key, so it cannot be skipped.

EVERY HIDING PLACE AND WHAT GOES IN IT

PLACE	CONTENTS
HER HANDS	The welcome letter and the Milk Crate painting. Nothing is hidden on the painting; its back just carries the written clue.
OUT IN THE OPEN	Seven printed sheets scattered about: knife catalogue, songbook, Stars and Their Notes, receipt book, register, cartomancer's guide, concordance. NOT the pig-pen key (liquor cabinet) and NOT the two plates (backgammon set, Dutch oven). Also the flyer on the fridge; a bowl of lemons, one loaded; the knife and the kitchen scale on the counter; The Prophet on the shelf among many books; the locked suitcase
BACKGAMMON SET	Plate II; the Patricia painting
WINGSPAN BOX	The Hamlet painting; the fairy painting; a real Queen of Hearts playing card
TOILET CISTERN	The BLACK key in a ziplock bag. Nothing else, ever. No paper, no paintings.
THE CANDY JAR	The blue-light pen and the framer's delivery card, rolled together. No paintings in here any more: the card is what tells her where the two of them are.
ABYSSINIA PAINTING	Taped flat to the inside of a kitchen cupboard door. Named by the framer's card. Nothing else goes here.
GLEANERS PAINTING	Standing on its edge between two dinner plates in the cupboard. Named by the framer's card. Nothing else goes here.
LIQUOR CABINET	The Pig-Pen Alphabet key sheet
DUTCH OVEN	Plate I, with a paper fastener taped to it (the brass pin with two flat legs; she pushes it through both discs and bends the legs back so the top disc spins)
BATHROOM WALL OR MIRROR	ALIEN BLUES in dry-erase marker; the pigpen glyphs from the tracing sheet in invisible ink beneath
INSIDE THE MEDITATION CUSHION	The cipher card, in a small envelope, tucked just inside the zip where a hand will meet it
BEHIND THE FRAMED PHOTO PUZZLE	The DARK BLUE key, taped flat to the back of the frame. Nothing points here until the wheel is decoded, so it is never searched.
SUITCASE	The backpack. The suitcase itself is padlocked with the BLACK lock and left in plain sight all evening.
BACKPACK	The prize. Padlocked with the DARK BLUE lock. All six paintings are placed elsewhere; none is in here.

1 • THE WELCOME LETTER. Your words, your handwriting. It must do three jobs and no more: give her the address `sarahs.quest`; warn her that some things she finds will not make sense on the day she finds them; and end with a line in your own voice. Do not explain any puzzle. Do not mention the suitcase. If you are stuck for an opening: *“There are six paintings in this apartment and every one of them is a question. You will need a scale, a knife, a pin, and more patience than I deserve.”*

2 • THE SIX PAINTING BACKS. Write these on the quarter-sheet frames and clip or tape one to each painting.

MILK CRATE — *The famous man we always see here, who is not him.*

PATRICIA’S — *Just the name. Look her up.*

HAMLET — *We saw the film of this play. Whose film was it? Look her up by her first name.*

FAIRY HOUSES — *What was the family name of the one who lived here? Look her up.*

ABYSSINIA — *This country has another name now. Find its colours at `sarahs.quest`, and turn them over.*

GLEANERS — *The café sits in a market named for a country. Its colours are at `sarahs.quest` too. You will need this one and Abyssinia both.*

3 • THE WALL. Two inks on one surface. The tracing sheet two pages back shows the whole thing laid out.

LINE ONE, DRY-ERASE MARKER, LARGE: ALIEN BLUES

LINE TWO, MIXED. The lowercase words go in dry-erase marker. The CAPITAL words go in invisible ink, as pig-pen shapes, in the gaps:

BREATHE in BREATHE out open the GREEN thing you SIT on

So what she sees walking in is *ALIEN BLUES* / ___ in ___ out open the ___ thing you ___ on, a sentence with holes in it. Under the blue light the holes fill with shapes, and with the pig-pen sheet the shapes read BREATHE, BREATHE, GREEN, SIT. That is 22 shapes to draw. The visible words give nothing away; the hidden ones are the answer, so she still needs the pen and the sheet. Test a corner first: glass and glazed tile wipe clean, grout and stone do not. The mirror is the safest surface in the room.

4 • THE CIPHER CARD. Any scrap of paper. In capitals, exactly, with the spaces where they are:

DW5OY7 H5W VKYJ LKR WQ

Put it in a small envelope. On the envelope write: *This will mean nothing until the hour is set.* Tuck it just inside the cushion’s zip, where a hand will meet it straight away.

5 • THREE HINT ENVELOPES (optional, but they save the evening). Seal three envelopes and label them *If you are stuck on the music*, *If you are stuck on the knife*, and *If you are stuck at the very end*. Inside each, one sentence: *Everything you need is at `sarahs.quest/hints.html` — and I will not think less of you.*

WHAT YOU DO NOT WRITE

The flags’ pigpen is already on the website. The register, the card guide, the concordance, the songbook, the knife catalogue and the recipe book are printed and final. The only cipher you draw by hand is the wall.

THE FIVE TESTS, BEFORE SHE ARRIVES

1. **The knife.** Put your real knife on your real scale. It must read 79 g. The nearest catalogue entries are 58 g and 99 g, so you have about 14 g of slack either way. If it is wildly off, pick a different knife.
2. **The book.** Open your copy of *The Prophet*. Page 12, fourth word of the first line, must be **corn**. Page 15, the first sentence beginning “Give”, sixth word, must be **bread**. Editions differ and this is the single most likely thing to break.
3. **The wall.** Shine the blue-light pen on your writing. The hidden shapes must show clearly between the marker words. Then wipe a corner to be certain both inks come off.
4. **The wheel.** Cut both plates, pin them, set the hands to half past three, and decode the cipher card yourself. It must read BEHIND THE MANY FACES.
5. **The website.** Open [sarahs.quest](#) on your phone. Tap Figure VII, the green-yellow-red flag with the blue disc: its back must read HALF PAST. Then tap Figure XIV, the green-white-red vertical stripes: its back must read THREE. Together they give half past three.

THE ORDER TO SET THE ROOM UP

1. Lock the backpack, put it in the suitcase, lock the suitcase, stand it in the open.
2. Hide the two keys: BLACK in the cistern, DARK BLUE behind the framed puzzle.
3. Place all six paintings: Milk Crate in her envelope; Patricia in the backgammon set; Hamlet and the fairy houses in the Wingspan box with the Queen of Hearts; Abyssinia and Gleaners in the two places the framer’s card names. None goes in the backpack, and none goes in the candy jar.
4. Blue-light pen and the framer’s delivery card into the candy jar, rolled together. Check the card names the two places you actually used.
5. Plate II in the backgammon set. Plate I in the Dutch oven. Pig-pen sheet in the liquor cabinet.
6. Load one lemon with the Joker and set the bowl out. Knife and scale on the counter.
7. Cipher card into the cushion. Write the wall. Flyer on the fridge.
8. Scatter the seven open sheets around the room: knife catalogue, songbook, Stars and Their Notes, receipt book, register, cartomancer’s guide, concordance. The Prophet onto the shelf among other books. Keep the pig-pen key and both plates for their hiding places.
9. Tear the last **seven** leaves out of the printed packet and hide them from yourself: the wall to trace, these five guide pages, and the cipher solution. The wall sheet is the first of the seven and it gives the answer away, so count from the back and be sure you have all seven.

IF SHE STALLS

[sarahs.quest/hints.html](#) holds a hint for every predicament in the game, each with a nudge, then a firmer nudge, then the answer outright. It is linked in a box at the top of the flags page, so she can reach it on her own and you never have to be the one who gives it away. Or just tell her; you are allowed.